

How to Sleep Better with Arthritis

Struggling to sleep with arthritis? Evidence-based UK tips for better rest including mattress choices, pillow positioning, pain relief timing, and NHS sleep support.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-09 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Sleep disturbance affects up to **80% of people with arthritis**. Pain, stiffness, and discomfort can make falling asleep difficult and staying asleep even harder. Yet good sleep is essential for managing arthritis — poor sleep increases pain sensitivity and inflammation.

Why Arthritis Disrupts Sleep

- Night-time pain — inflammatory cytokines peak during the night, increasing pain
 - Morning stiffness — joints stiffen overnight, causing discomfort that wakes you
 - Difficulty finding comfortable positions
 - Medication side effects — steroids can cause insomnia
 - Anxiety and low mood — common with chronic pain conditions
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Sleep Position Tips



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For Knee Arthritis

Place a pillow between your knees when sleeping on your side, or under your knees when on your back. This maintains alignment and reduces pressure.

For Hip Arthritis

Sleep on the non-affected side with a pillow between your knees. A mattress topper can help distribute pressure more evenly.

For Back Arthritis

Sleep on your back with a pillow under your knees, or on your side in a foetal position with a pillow between your knees.

For Shoulder Arthritis

Avoid sleeping on the affected shoulder. Hug a pillow to support the arm in a comfortable position.

Mattress and Pillow Choices

- Medium-firm mattress — provides support without creating pressure points
 - Memory foam topper — moulds to your body shape (£30-80 from Argos, Dunelm)
 - Supportive pillow — memory foam or contoured pillows maintain neck alignment
 - V-shaped pillow — useful for propping up and supporting multiple joints
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Pain Relief Timing



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Speak to your GP about timing your pain medication so it's most effective during the night. Slow-release anti-inflammatories taken at bedtime can help some people.

Sleep Hygiene for Arthritis

- Keep a consistent bedtime and wake time
 - Take a warm bath or shower before bed — heat relaxes muscles and eases stiffness
 - Keep bedroom temperature at 16-18°C
 - Avoid screens for 30 minutes before bed
 - Try relaxation techniques — the NHS Couch to 5K app includes sleep stories
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When to Get Help



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If sleep problems persist despite these measures, speak to your GP. The NHS offers:

- CBT for insomnia (CBT-i) — available through NHS Talking Therapies
- Sleep clinics — specialist assessment for complex sleep problems
- Pain management programmes — multidisciplinary approach to chronic pain

Good sleep is a vital part of arthritis management. Don't accept poor sleep as inevitable — help is available through the NHS.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about how to sleep better with arthritis?

Short answer: To sleep better with arthritis, adjust your sleep position, use a medium-firm mattress, and consider a supportive pillow. For knee arthritis, place a pillow between or under your knees. For hip arthritis, sleep on your non-affected side with a pillow between knees. Timing pain medication to be effective at night, maintaining good sleep hygiene, and relaxing before bed can also help.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk